

Belarus



Literally "White Russia," Belarus lies landlocked in eastern Europe. It reluctantly became independent when the USSR broke up in 1991. It has few resources other than agriculture.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly plains and low hills. The Dnieper and Dvina rivers drain the eastern lowlands. Vast Pripyet Marshes in the southwest.



CLIMATE

Extreme continental climate. Winters are long, sub-freezing, but mainly dry; summers are hot.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Only 2% of people are non-Slav, so ethnic tension is minimal. Russian culture dominates. Belarus was the slowest ex-Soviet state to implement political reform; President Lukashenko has been labeled as Europe's last dictator. Enthusiasm for a merger with Russia has waned. Wealth is held by a small ex-Communist elite. Fallout from the 1986 Chernobyl nuclear disaster in Ukraine still seriously affects health and the environment.



THE ECONOMY

Low unemployment. Industry outmoded and mainly state-owned. Depends on Russia for energy and raw materials; tensions over natural gas prices.



INSIGHT: *The number of cancer and leukemia cases soared after the 1986 Chernobyl disaster*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Belarus

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Minsk

POPULATION: 9.63 million

TOTAL AREA: 80,154 sq. miles
(207,600 sq. km)

DENSITY: 120 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Belarussian*, Russian*

RELIGIONS: Orthodox Christian 60%, other (including Muslim, Jewish, and Protestant) 32%, Roman Catholic 8%

ETHNIC MIX: Belarussian 81%, Russian 11%, Polish 4%, Ukrainian 2%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Belarussian rouble = 100 kopeks